



Vital cog: He played an integral role in India winning a historic team bronze at the 2018 Asian Games and gold medals at the Commonwealth Games.

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trials, they didn't want to break my heart and thought such a young kid wouldn't be selected anyway. But once I got selected, they were shocked. I wasn't even thinking about staying away from my parents and family for a year. I stayed there for one year, went to a couple of national ranking tournaments, won a title in the under-10 category before coming back home due to homesickness. I was so young that I used to wet my bed at night."

The one year at PSPB turned out to be a game-changer for Harmeet. Not only did it give him a taste of the outside world, but he also had to cope with being ragged by seniors. "They taught me swear words, and I had no clue they were swear words," he says.

However, it was his wait for a phone call from home every evening — an STD call to the hostel — that eventually got to him. Having switched their careers and doing their best to fund his table tennis coaching, placing an STD call every day was not really affordable for the Desais. But they ensured that at least one of the extended family members called Harmeet to make him comfortable.

While the PSPB Academy has a reputation for making champions, it has also seen numerous cases of ruining promising careers. "There was a saying there that the one who leaves the Academy never becomes a player. I think it's just me who came out of the Academy and made it into the senior team or played really well after that," he says with a sense of pride.

"I wanted to prove to everyone that I could become good. After two or three years, I got another offer